a free pass for India, without corresponding commitments to the NPT regime. Nonetheless, America was the world's only super-power, and the NSG's endorsement of the India–US nuclear deal in terms of giving India a clean waiver to source nuclear technology and materials without signing the NPT, while likely to face many problems including from friendly European states and non-aligned countries, was still an objective worth pursing. France* and the United Kingdom were expected to follow the American lead; Russia was favourable. China, however, was a question mark.

The upheaval that the Indian nuclear tests in 1998 had caused in India–China relations had been smoothed over by 2003, but within China it had led to a re-evaluation of India generally and, more specifically, of India's nuclear programme. The simplistic explanation for this re-evaluation was that China now had an overt nuclear weapons state on its disputed south-western border that had also levelled allegations about China being a threat in order to justify India's nuclear tests. However, the fact remains that the tests did not significantly change the ground realities for China; what did change was the perception that China was no longer the sole Asian nuclear weapons state. After India had tested in 1998, China's approach on the Nuclear Question vis-à-vis India was shaped by two concerns. One was over the convergences between the Americans and India, and the conclusion of the Indo–US nuclear deal suggested to the Chinese that such convergences were growing. Another concern arose from the challenge that the Indian nuclear tests posed to the carefully constructed Chinese narrative that China was the sole legitimate Asian nuclear weapons state.

In the early 1960s, the Chinese had already guessed that India was also developing nuclear weapons technology. Yet their carefully constructed narrative did not make mention of India's